

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Numbers

Numbers

The book of Numbers tells the story of Israel in the wilderness. The people traveled from Mount Sinai toward the promised land. Moses led Israel from Egypt to Canaan. During this journey, God tested his people. He wanted to show whether they would be faithful to him as one nation.

Numbers tells about Israel's successes and failures. When Israel disobeyed, the Lord judged them. Yet the Lord was also patient. He continued to guide his people and raised up a new generation to carry out his plan.

Numbers includes many stories and many of God's laws. Together, these show who the Lord is, what his covenant (binding agreement) means, and what he planned for his people.

Setting

After the Israelites left Egypt, they traveled to Mount Sinai. There God gave them the law. The book of Exodus tells this story. The Israelites stayed at Sinai for one year. Then they traveled through the wilderness to Transjordan, the land east of the Jordan River. They camped on the plains of Moab. God tested Israel in the wilderness. During this time, the generation that had left Egypt died. A new generation prepared to enter the promised land. The book of Numbers taught this new generation to obey the Lord. This generation was camped on the plains of Moab.

God formed and made ready Israel during this time in the wilderness. Moses wrote down this story. Later scribes and editors also helped preserve it. Through the book of Numbers, later generations could hear what happened to Israel. For this reason, Numbers became an important part of Israel's memory. It taught later generations to learn from the past. Those who learned from Israel's history did not need to repeat the same mistakes.

Summary

The book of Numbers has three main parts. These parts follow the three stages of Israel's journey through the wilderness:

1. Israel spent 19 days getting ready to leave Mount Sinai (1:1-10:10).
2. Israel traveled for 39 years from Sinai to the plains of Moab (10:11-22:1).

3. Israel spent its final months camped on the plains of Moab. This happened shortly before the people entered Canaan (21:1-36:13).

The book of Numbers is also shaped by two counts of Israel's men who were old enough to serve in the army (Numbers 1-4, 26). These counts measured the size of Israel's army. They also counted the Levites, the tribe that served at the tabernacle. The first count comes near the beginning of the book. It counted the generation that left Egypt, received the law at Sinai, rebelled against the Lord, and died in the wilderness. The second count comes near the end of the book. It counted the new generation of Israelites who would enter the promised land. The two totals are very close. This shows that the second generation fully replaced the first.

Along the way, the Israelites who left Egypt rebelled against the Lord many times (Numbers 11, 12, 14, 16-17, 20, 25). All of them died in the wilderness except Joshua and Caleb. Joshua and Caleb trusted the Lord and obeyed him (13:30; 14:6-9).

Israel's army was tested several times before the people entered Canaan (Numbers 14, 21, 31). Numbers also tells the story of Balaam (22-24). The book explains how some Israelites settled in Transjordan, the land east of the Jordan River (chapter 32). It also reviews Israel's journey through the wilderness (33). Then Moses prepared the people to enter and take possession of Canaan (chapters 34-36).

Numbers shows how Israel kept, and failed to keep, the covenant rules in daily life.

Author

As with the other books of the Pentateuch, the first five books of the Bible, Moses has traditionally been seen as the author of Numbers. Before modern biblical scholarship began, both Jewish and Christian scholars accepted Moses as the author. The Old Testament, the New Testament, and much ancient Jewish writing also assume this. The Pentateuch often refers to Moses writing things down. For example, Numbers says that Moses recorded the stages of Israel's journey (Numbers 33:1-2).

There is no clear reason to reject Moses as the main author of Numbers. The content of the book does not require this. People could also read and write at the time of the exodus from Egypt and the conquest of Canaan. However, some passages were likely added or edited later, such as the account of Moses's death (Deuteronomy 34). It is also possible that Moses guided the writing and gathering of the

books connected with him. Like the apostle Paul, he may also have spoken some parts aloud for others to write down.

Many scholars think that later editors used several sources to form the books of the Pentateuch. This view is called the Documentary Hypothesis. It remains uncertain because it is based on scholarly reconstruction (see Genesis Book Introduction, “Author”). Even if later scribes and editors made some changes, Numbers mainly presents itself as the work of Moses.

Date and Geography

The geographical, cultural, and language details in Numbers can fit either an early or a late date for the exodus from Egypt and the conquest of Canaan. These possible dates are the 1400s BC or the 1200s BC. (see Exodus Book Introduction, “The Date of the Exodus”).

Archaeological evidence from Sinai, the Negev, and Transjordan region (Edom, Moab, and Ammon) greatly helps in discussing the history of the conquering of Canaan. Scholars struggle to find exact locations for many place names in the wilderness travel route. There are also issues with other sites named in the Book of Numbers.

Literary Issues

Title of the Book

The name Numbers comes from the book’s focus on counting the people of Israel (see chapters 1–4, 26). The English title comes from the Latin title *Numeri* and the Greek title *Arithmoi*. These were the titles used in the Latin Vulgate and the Greek Septuagint, two early translations of the Old Testament. The two counts show clearly that the Israelites who left Egypt were not the same generation that crossed the Jordan River into Canaan.

In the Hebrew Bible, the book is called *bemidbar* (meaning “in the wilderness”). This is the fourth word of Numbers 1:1 in the Hebrew text. This title also fits the book well. It points to where the story takes place and to the time Israel spent in the wilderness.

Literary Genres

The book of Numbers includes several kinds of writing. These include:

- story (Numbers 10:11–14:45),
- poetry (Numbers 23–24), and
- laws (Numbers 4–6).

Numbers also includes detailed lists of names, numbers, and events. These lists include counts of:

- the people (for example, Numbers 1–4),
- offerings brought to the Lord (Numbers 7), and
- the places where the Israelites traveled (Numbers 33).

Literary Sources

The Hebrew Bible names some ancient sources that Moses, and perhaps later editors, used when writing Numbers. These include:

- The Book of the Wars of the Lord (Numbers 21:14–15),
- the “Song of the Well,” (21:7–18), and
- the “Song of Heshbon” (21:27–30).

Numbers 23–24 includes many lines of poetry from Balaam, a prophet who was not an Israelite. Numbers 31:32–47 seems to come from a record of the goods taken after war. Numbers 33 appears to come from a written travel record.

Text

The Hebrew text of Numbers has been preserved very well. However, some poetry in Numbers 21–24 is hard to interpret. We can see that the Hebrew text is in good condition by comparing two sources. The first is the Hebrew Masoretic Text, which comes from the AD 900s. The second is earlier copies of parts of Numbers found among the Dead Sea Scrolls. These copies date from about 150 BC to AD 125. There are only a few small differences between them.

There are greater differences between the Masoretic Text, the Greek Old Testament called the Septuagint, and the Samaritan Pentateuch. The Samaritan Pentateuch is the version of the first five books of the Bible used by the Samaritan community. These differences usually show deliberate interpretation. They are not only small differences between manuscript copies.

Meaning and Message

Numbers explains how God provided for his people’s needs. It also tells how the Israelites disobeyed him again and again. They rebelled against the Lord’s commands. The Israelites did not spend 40 years in the wilderness because they were lost. They stayed there because they did not trust the Lord and rebelled against him.

The book of Numbers shows Israel’s struggle to obey God. God often called the Israelites to follow his law, but they disobeyed him. The Israelites could depend on God to give them what they needed. He gave them food, water, guidance, and teaching through the leaders he had chosen. Yet the people often failed to trust him. The book of Numbers shows that the holy

God judges sin quickly. It also teaches that the Lord is faithful and patient.

Like ancient Israel, every community of believers needs strong and faithful leaders. The book of Numbers also warns people who too easily forget that God is holy.

The New Testament uses several events from Numbers as powerful lessons:

- In 1 Corinthians 10:1–11, the apostle Paul warns his readers not to worship idols, commit sexual sin, or complain against God. He tells them not to die like the Israelites in the wilderness. God is not pleased with this kind of behavior. Followers of Christ must not test God (1 Corinthians 10:9).
- The author of Hebrews points to several times when Israel was stubborn and disobeyed God. He says that God responded to their rebellion with quick and certain judgment (Hebrews 3:7–4:11). These verses use much of the language of Psalm 95. They also include many words that show God's judgment against Israel's sin.
- Jude 1:5 teaches Christians about faithfulness by summarizing the book of Numbers.

The same God who freed his people from Egypt also destroyed that rebellious generation. They died because they did not trust and obey him. Like ancient Israel, Christians must learn from the mistakes of the past. They must live with faith in the Lord and obey him.